criticising Moscow would amount to backstabbing a friendly power without earning practical support from the West. Washington, Beijing, and Islamabad, Charan Singh knew, would resist Soviet forces in Afghanistan regardless of India's stand.

The Soviet intervention, however, had occurred during an interregnum in Indian politics, with polls scheduled for early January 1980 and Charan Singh's bête noire Indira Gandhi's victory almost certain. Not only did this reduce the political costs of criticising the Soviet Union, it gave Charan Singh a golden opportunity to chastise Moscow, with whom he never really got along. Without hesitation, Charan Singh castigated Vorontsov and unequivocally rejected the Soviet intervention. Any development that would change the qualitative nature of the polity of a neighbouring country concerned India considerably, and Moscow was asked to remove its troops as soon as possible.[10] As far as Charan Singh was concerned, India would criticise the Soviet Union both in Moscow and at the UN. Brajesh Mishra, India's representative at the UN, communicated Charan Singh's stand to other UN delegations.[11] He also protested American and Chinese arms supplies to Pakistan while the MEA communicated the same to Robert Goheen, the US ambassador to India, and Clark Clifford, US President Jimmy Carter's special envoy.[12] In the meantime, as it was expected, Indira Gandhi swept the polls. A pro-Soviet leader, she began exerting control over foreign policy even before her institution as the PM on 20 January 1980. Within a mere fortnight, Gandhi undid Charan Singh's stance.

Aware of the irreconcilable dilemma facing India in the wake of Soviet actions, Gandhi adopted a complicated three-pronged balancing strategy. India would say one thing at the UN, another to Kabul and Moscow, and launch an entirely different initiative with the West and Pakistan. Firstly, on 12 January 1980, Gandhi instructed Mishra to retract his previous statement criticising the Soviet Union at the UN. Instead, he was to inform the UNGA, at the 'Uniting for Peace' initiative launched by Western capitals, that Moscow had sent troops on Afghan request and would not stay there a day longer than required.[13] While India was averse to the presence of foreign troops and bases in any country, it had no reason to doubt assurances 'particularly by a friendly country such as the Soviet Union'.[14] Mishra then charged the US, China, and Pakistan for colluding